

5 failure modes that quietly kill AI adoption programs, and the early-warning sign for each

1. Pilot purgatory.

The pilot never ends, because the charter never gave it a way to end.

Warning sign: no kill condition, no dated decision, silent renewals.

2. Tool sprawl.

AI tools multiply across teams while nobody can list what's in use or what it costs per active seat.

Warning sign: new tools show up in expense reports you didn't approve.

3. Productivity theater.

Activity metrics light up. Value per active seat stays flat.

Warning sign: the deck shows logins and licenses, not outcomes.

4. Cognitive debt.

People offload the thinking to the assistant and ship confident wrong answers.

Warning sign: rework climbs and nobody's tracking it.

5. Champion burnout.

Every thread runs through one person, so the program's memory walks out the door when they do.

Warning sign: no second pair of hands, no mentor layer, and you're working evenings to keep the program alive.

Score your program on all five, every quarter.

The self-assessment ships in The AI Champion's Playbook, 2nd edition.

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